Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Dickinson Public Library
City of Dickinson
4403 Highway 3, Dickinson, TX 77539

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position at the Dickinson Public Library. I have spent the last four years in nonprofit development, but the work I have consistently gravitated toward is organizing material so other people can find it, and I am now moving toward library work deliberately rather than by accident.

The part of your posting I want to answer directly is the requirement to assist patrons with library software, e-resources and public computers. In my current role I oversee a physical archive of printed materials, and when I found that nobody on staff could locate anything in it, I built a searchable reading room and the database behind it. I now maintain both and help colleagues who get stuck. Outside of work I founded the Free Knowledge Library, an archive cataloging political literature where I designed the classification scheme and built the catalog, and StateTrack, a public database of state campaign finance records covering all fifty states. Helping someone find what they are looking for in a system, or fix it when it will not cooperate, is work I genuinely like.

The rest of the duty list is familiar too. As a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law I staffed the service window, which meant assisting people in person, explaining policies that were not obvious, and processing more than five hundred records accurately. At the University of Austin I handled intake and documentation of library donations and was the person who walked visitors through the library and answered their questions. Shelving, checking materials in and out, keeping public spaces orderly, and helping at programs are all things I am ready to do from day one.

I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I have family in Southern California who can host me during an interim move, and I am willing to go anywhere in Texas that a position requires. Dickinson is a move I would make gladly for a full-time role in a library.

I have started the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I am not looking for a stopgap. Thank you for your time, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie